Mountbatten Plan was announced for the partition of India. The date fixed for the division of British India was 15 August, and the proclamation of the Radcliffe Award, which would define the exact alignment of the border between India and Pakistan, was scheduled for the next day, 16 August. This was wrong, in my opinion, as people who owned properties didn't want to abandon them till they were sure of the boundary. Some of the landlords even converted to Islam and stayed behind to keep their lands! Till the time the Radcliffe line was clearly established, there were millions of affected people who couldn't take any decision about their future. When they finally did make up their minds, it proved to be too late and calamitous for many of them, for in the bargain they lost their lives too.

My grandparents and other family members, who were mainly Punjabi Khatris, both Sikhs and Hindus, were uprooted and devastated. My grandfather, a disabled veteran of the First World War and his family, and that of Anupama (I call her Rohini), my future wife, had little choice but to migrate to the Indian part of the subcontinent.

They were not only a witness to many horrendous incidents, but also suffered untold pain and misery themselves. An example in our family was the assumed violent death of Rohini's elderly grandmother; her body was never found. This period thus had an indelible and traumatic effect on this generation's psyche and life as also that of their children. Khushwant Singh's unforgettable book, *Train to Pakistan*, gives a moving account of this tragic period. The whole thing was a human tragedy of unimaginable dimensions, and possibly avoidable, according to some contemporary historians.

As a result of this Partition, the armed forces and their assets were also divided between the two nations. Regimental histories were torn asunder. Vertical splits and division of manpower and equipment took place in various regiments of cavalry and artillery, and in infantry battalions of mixed-class composition. The farewells were carried out in a spirit of bonhomie between the parting soldiers, who were comrades-in-arms till that day. Barring a few exceptions, the Muslims on one hand and the Hindus and Sikhs on